

ChatGPT Version 5.2 Thinking

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I need help with information about some of the mercenary companies that existed in France and Iberia during the One Hundred Years War. I have found a document from 1387 that mentions the mercenary company led by people whose names are something like Gauterio de Passach and Guillermo de Vilars. It seems from the document I am working with that the mercenary company wanted to journey from France through the Crown of Aragon and into Castile. Can you locate any information about this in academic sources? Please provide links to journal articles or academic monographs in your answer.

I'm checking for those names in scholarship and also for broader references to free companies crossing or seeking passage through the Crown of Aragon into Castile in the late 1380s. I'll anchor on variant spellings, since these names often shift a lot across Latin, Catalan, Castilian, and French sources.

I've got a likely identification for one of the names: "Gauterio de Passach" is very probably **Gaucher (or Gautier) de Passac**, a French captain/chamberlain active in the 1386–1387 French expedition to aid Juan I of Castile. The second name may be trickier; I'm checking whether your "Guillermo de Vilars" is really a different captain or a paleographic misread of **Guillaume de Naillac** or **Guillaume de Lignac**, both of whom appear in the scholarship on this expedition.

Thought for 2m 32s

Yes. I found a strong match for one of your names, and a probable correction for the other.

The captain in your 1387 document is very likely **Gaucher (also written Gautier/Gautier) de Passac**. In the scholarly literature on the French intervention in Iberia during the John of Gaunt crisis, he appears as one of the French royal captains sent to aid **Juan I of Castile** in 1387. A standard modern monograph states that on **5 February 1387** Charles VI sent **Guillaume de Naillac** and **Gaucher de Passac** to Castile at the head of about **2,000 men-at-arms**.

Your second name, however, is less secure. I did **not** find a solid academic hit for a captain named “**Guillermo de Vilars**” in this 1387 context. The two names that repeatedly appear with Passac in academic and source-based scholarship are:

- **Guillaume de Naillac**, in some modern studies and archival notices.
- **Guillaume de Lignac**, especially in Froissart-related scholarship and tradition.

So paleographically, your “Guillermo de Vilars” may well be a misreading of **Guillaume de Naillac** or **Guillaume de Lignac**, depending on the language and script of the record.

What the scholarship says

The basic historical setting is the French expedition sent to support Juan I of Castile against the Anglo-Portuguese challenge associated with John of Gaunt. Modern scholarship consistently places **Passac** among the French leaders of that intervention.

One useful academic article, though focused on Froissart and pilgrimage routes, explicitly identifies the captains as **Gautier de Passac** and **Guillaume de Naillac**, and says that according to Froissart they crossed **Navarre** and reached **Logroño and Burgos**. That matters because it shows that at least one scholarly strand understands the expedition’s movement into Castile through the Pyrenean-western route, not necessarily through the Crown of Aragon.

But another scholarly reference drawing on Froissart preserves a slightly different naming and route tradition: it refers to **Guillaume de Lignac** together with **Passac**, and places them at **Carcassonne**, expecting to cross the **Garonne at Toulouse** and proceed southward toward the Pyrenean zone on their way to aid the king of Castile.

That means your Aragonese document is very plausible historically even if the best-known narrative tradition routes the force via Navarre. The document you have may reflect:

1. a projected or negotiated transit through lands of the Crown of Aragon,
2. a sub-group or related company distinct from the better-known main route,
3. or a chancery record preserving diplomatic planning rather than the final itinerary.

Especially useful academic links

Here are the best sources I found that you can use immediately:

1. **Neil Murphy and Graeme Small (trans. and eds.), *The Chivalric Biography of Boucicaut, Jean II Le Meingre***

This modern scholarly book includes the note identifying the 1387 mission: Charles

VI sent **Guillaume de Naillac** and **Gaucher de Passac** to Castile with 2,000 men-at-arms.

2. **Jeanne Vielliard and Léon Mirot, “Inventaire des lettres des rois d’Aragon à Charles VI et à la cour de France, conservées aux Archives de la Couronne d’Aragon à Barcelone,” *Bibliothèque de l’École des chartes* 103 (1942)**

This is highly relevant because it is an academic article built directly from ACA diplomatic material and includes notices linking French court figures to Iberian business; the search snippet explicitly notes that one courtier “accompanied Gautier de Passac in Spain.”

3. **Ignacio Iñarrea Las Heras, “Los caminos de Santiago y los conflictos dinásticos castellanos en las *Chroniques* de Jean Froissart,” *Thélème* (2009)**

This article is valuable for the route question. The available abstract/snippet identifies **Gautier de Passac** and **Guillaume de Naillac** and says Froissart has them passing through **Navarre** to **Logroño and Burgos**.

4. **J.-F. Massie, “À l’ombre de Fébus : Arnaud-Guilhem de Béarn...,” *Annales du Midi* 98 (1986)**

The snippet is useful because it preserves a Froissart-derived notice placing **Lignac** and **Passac** at **Carcassonne** and describing their intended southward movement toward Castile.

5. **Louis Douët d’Arcq, ed., *Choix de pièces inédites relatives au règne de Charles VI*, vol. 1 (1863)**

This is an edited primary-source collection rather than a journal article, but it is still a very useful scholarly edition. A cited modern note quotes the document stating that **Guillaume de Naillac and Gaucher de Passac** undertook, for **100,000 francs**, to lead **2,000 men-at-arms** sent to help the king of Castile.

My best reconstruction

Based on the academic material I found, the most likely reading of your document is:

- **Gauterio de Passach = Gaucher/Gautier de Passac**
- **Guillermo de Vilars** = probably **Guillaume de Naillac** or **Guillaume de Lignac**, not an otherwise unattested “Vilars”

And the broader event is the **French expedition of 1387 to support Juan I of Castile** during the later phase of the Anglo-Portuguese-Castilian struggle connected to John of Gaunt.

What I did **not** find is a clean academic article saying, in so many words, “Passac and X crossed the Crown of Aragon into Castile.” The scholarship I found more often gives the route as **through Navarre**, while your document suggests either an alternate route or a diplomatic plan involving Aragonese transit.

If you paste the exact wording of the 1387 document, I can try to pin down whether your second name is closer to **Naillac**, **Lignac**, or something else entirely, and whether the passage through the Crown of Aragon was planned, granted, or merely rumored.

You are correct that the second name is Guillermo de Naillac. Now that I am looking at the paleography again, I can see this clearly. Can you please provide me more information about the French expedition of 1387 and how it connected to John of Gaunt? If you can find any English-language academic sources that would be the most helpful.

I’m pulling together the English-language scholarship on the 1387 French expedition and the John of Gaunt connection, and I’m prioritizing sources that explain the politics rather than just naming the captains. I’ll also separate what is firmly attested from what looks like inference from chronicle traditions.

Thought for 1m 3s

Yes. In English-language scholarship, the 1387 French expedition is usually explained as **a counter-move against John of Gaunt’s attempt to seize the crown of Castile**.

The basic sequence is this. John of Gaunt claimed the Castilian throne through his wife **Constance of Castile**, daughter of Pedro I. In **1386** he launched a major Iberian expedition, landing in Galicia and pressing his dynastic claim with Portuguese support. That Anglo-Portuguese alignment mattered because Portugal had just been drawn firmly into alliance with England, and Portuguese backing gave Gaunt a base from which to threaten Juan I of Castile. English-language scholarship treats this as part of the wider Anglo-French struggle: Gaunt’s Castilian venture was not a sideshow, but one Iberian front of the Hundred Years’ War.

The **French expedition of 1387** was therefore sent to **help Juan I of Castile resist Gaunt**. A modern English scholarly edition states that on **5 February 1387** Charles VI dispatched **Guillaume de Naillac** and **Gaucher de Passac** with about **2,000 men-at-arms** to Castile, and that a second force led by the duke of Bourbon arrived later that

summer. That matches the names in your document and strongly suggests that your Aragonese record belongs to the diplomatic and logistical world created by this anti-Gaunt intervention.

How this connected to John of Gaunt

The connection is direct:

- **Gaunt's invasion created the need for French aid to Castile.**
Because Gaunt was the leading English prince and was pursuing a real dynastic claim in Iberia, French support for Juan I was a way to block English power from gaining a foothold in Castile.
- **Portugal was the hinge.**
The Anglo-Portuguese alliance gave Gaunt essential support against Castile, and English-language scholarship stresses that Portuguese willingness to back English claims to Castile was one reason the alliance mattered so much in European politics.
- **The expedition was part of the same diplomatic-military cycle that ended in settlement rather than conquest.**
By 1387–1388, Gaunt's campaign had stalled, and the conflict moved toward negotiated settlement. The preliminary **Treaties of Trancoso (1387)** and the **Treaty of Bayonne (1388)** ended Gaunt's active claim in exchange for marriage and compensation arrangements.

One useful point for your specific document: some scholarship associated with Froissart has the French captains moving by a western route, especially through **Navarre** toward **Logroño** and **Burgos**. But that does **not** rule out an Aragonese connection in your source. An ACA document could easily preserve a planned transit, safe-conduct negotiation, intelligence about intended movement, or a branch route before the final march.

Best English-language academic sources

These are the most useful English-language works I found with links:

Anthony Goodman, *John of Gaunt: The Exercise of Princely Power in Fourteenth-Century Europe*

Still one of the standard English studies of Gaunt. Very helpful for the Castilian claim, the 1386–1388 campaign, and the political meaning of the Iberian expedition.

Link:

P. E. Russell, *The English Intervention in Spain and Portugal in the Time of Edward III and Richard II*

A classic English-language monograph. Old, but still foundational for the Anglo-Portuguese-Castilian context and Gaunt's intervention.

Link:

Neil Murphy and Graeme Small (eds./trans.), *The Chivalric Biography of Boucicaut, Jean II Le Meingre*

This is especially useful for your captains. It explicitly notes that on 5 February 1387 **Guillaume de Naillac** and **Gaucher de Passac** were sent by Charles VI to Castile with 2,000 men-at-arms.

Link:

The Treaty of Bayonne (1388), with preliminary Treaties of Trancoso (1387)

Useful for the endgame of the crisis and for seeing how Gaunt's military claim was converted into a diplomatic settlement.

Link:

M. Vale, "The Treaty of Windsor (1386) in a European Context"

Helpful for understanding why Portugal's alliance with England mattered so much to Castile and France, and therefore why the 1387 French expedition must be read as a response to the Gaunt-Portugal axis.

Link:

Anthony Goodman, "John of Gaunt: Paradigm of the Late Fourteenth-Century Crisis"

A shorter English article by the same scholar, useful for framing Gaunt's importance in the broader political crisis of the late fourteenth century.

Link:

A practical reading of your 1387 document

Given your corrected reading, the most likely interpretation is:

- your document refers to the **French expeditionary force** organized to aid **Juan I of Castile** against **John of Gaunt**;
- **Gauterio de Passach** = **Gaucher/Gautier de Passac**;
- **Guillermo de Naillac** = **Guillaume de Naillac**;
- the mention of movement through the Crown of Aragon probably reflects **transit planning, diplomatic clearance, or regional intelligence** connected to that expedition, even if some narrative sources emphasize a Navarrese route.

If you paste the relevant passage from your 1387 ACA document, I can help reconstruct what kind of movement it describes — safe-conduct, provisioning, passage rights, or intelligence about where the company intended to march.